Which brief should Freshroots build first?

Deepa's 90-day mandate · MESA AI-Native Track, Term 2, Case 01 · Assessed with the Nine Checks and the Five Pre-Build Decisions · 22 Oct 2026

Build Demand Planning first. It is the only brief that passes all nine checks. Distributor Service fails a kill switch: there is no input data. Operations Intelligence fails sizing and ownership checks: the bottleneck is who acts on the data, not the report. Of the three briefs, Demand Planning has the largest quantified loss (₹28–34 lakh a quarter), data that already exists, and rules the planner has already written down. Those rules cover 80–85% of decisions.

1 · The Nine Checks across the three briefs

Check	Demand Planning	Distributor Service	Operations Intelligence
KILL SWITCHES: ANY NO MEANS DON'T BUILD IT			
01 Problem real?	YES ₹18–22 L a quarter in stockouts plus ₹10–12 L in write-offs. The forecast is 3–4 weeks old when it reaches procurement.	PARTLY 3 distributors lost, 2 citing responsiveness, and a ₹28 L account cut its orders by 30%. The scale of the problem has not been measured.	YES A ₹9 L write-off after procurement acted on data that was 3 days old.
02 Workflow repeated?	YES Every month for 400 SKUs, taking 2 working days. The planner wants to run it twice a week.	YES 50–80 WhatsApp messages a day.	YES A 4-hour report every Monday.
03 Input available?	YES 3 years of SAP sales data, which IT can export. The sample exports pass validation with no errors: 15 SKUs, 16 weeks, a stock snapshot and the calendar.	NO Chats aren't archived, queries have never been categorised, and response times and resolution rate are unknown. "60–70% routine" is a guess.	YES 2 years of clean SAP data, and the 12 metrics are well defined.
SIZING: ANY NO MEANS BUILD SOMETHING SMALLER			
04 Output valuable?	YES The output feeds procurement's purchase orders directly.	n/a (killed at 03)	NO A faster dashboard doesn't change the weekly approval cycle. Deepa says the report isn't the bottleneck.
05 Impact measurable?	YES Stockout incidents, write-off value, the share of SKUs within their target stock range, and planning cycle time.	NO No baseline exists for response time or resolution.	WEAK One incident. How often it happens is unknown.
06 ROI worth it?	YES Cutting losses by 10% saves ₹2.8–3.4 L a quarter, or ₹11–14 L a year, against a ₹15 L budget. The build is	UNKNOWN Plausible (₹18–25 L a year per distributor) but can't be sized without data.	UNCLEAR One ₹9 L event plus 4 analyst hours a week.

Check	Demand Planning	Distributor Service	Operations Intelligence
	rules-based, so it is cheap to run.		
BOUNDARY: ANY NO MEANS PUT A HUMAN EXACTLY HERE			
07 Failure risk OK?	YES* A wrong purchase order costs money, so **a person approves every PO**. The engine never sends orders itself.	NO A wrong automated reply goes straight to a ₹20 L account.	YES Alerts are low-risk.
08 Judgment protected?	YES* The 15–20% of cases the rules don't cover (launches, unusual distributor behaviour, one-off events) go to Raghav as **MANUAL_REVIEW**.	—	—
09 Owner clear?	YES Raghav owns the rules, procurement owns approval, and Deepa sponsors.	PARTLY The CS lead, but there is no handoff protocol.	NO Nobody is named to act when a metric moves. That gap is the real problem.
Verdict	**BUILD NOW. The checks marked * set where the human approval step goes.**	**DON'T BUILD YET. First run a 4–6 week logging pilot: categorise every query and time every reply.**	**BUILD SMALLER, LATER. First fix who decides and how fast. Then add a small mid-week alert.**

Demand Planning also partly addresses the cadence problem in Operations Intelligence. Procurement starts acting on data from a twice-weekly run instead of a monthly forecast that is 3–4 weeks old.

2 · Five Pre-Build Decisions for Demand Planning

1 · Outcome definition: what must measurably change

- Fewer stockouts and fewer write-offs of perishable stock, measured in rupees each quarter against the ₹28–34 L baseline.
- More SKUs sitting inside their target stock range. That range is 6–14 weeks of stock for low-perishability SKUs and 3–4 weeks for high-perishability ones.
- The planning cycle moves from **monthly with data 3–4 weeks old** to **twice a week with data under 1 week old**.

2 · Baseline: the current state in numbers

From the brief

- Stockout losses: ₹18–22 L a quarter
- Overstock write-offs: ₹10–12 L a quarter, mostly perishables
- Cycle: once a month, 2 planner days, data 3–4 weeks old when used
- Rules cover 80–85% of decisions; 15–20% are judgment calls

From the SAP export (snapshot 19 Oct, week 42)

- 15 SKUs evaluated, 0 data-quality errors
- **8 of 15 (53%)** within their target range
- **5 (33%)** at stockout risk, including both perishable lines with under 2 weeks of stock
- **2 (13%)** overstocked: Quinoa at 22 weeks, Coconut Water at 4.1 weeks against a 4-week maximum

3 · Workflow change: what gets redesigned around the system

- **Before:** once a month, Raghav pulls data from SAP, works through it in Excel and writes a forecast. Procurement then raises purchase orders in Zoho.
- **After:** every Monday and Thursday the analyst uploads the SAP export. The engine applies Raghav's written rules to every SKU, and Gemini drafts a short planner brief.
- **Raghav** handles only the exceptions flagged MANUAL_REVIEW, about 15–20%.
- **Procurement** approves, edits or rejects each reorder in the app, then exports the approved orders, grouped by distributor, into Zoho.
- **What the system does not do:** AI never sets a quantity, and no order is sent without a named approver. The thresholds are a configuration file that Raghav owns.

4 · Measurement plan: in the world, not in the logs

- **Weeks 1–4, shadow mode.** The engine runs alongside Raghav. We measure how often its decisions match his on the SKUs the rules cover, and we record why each disagreement happened.
- **Quarter 1, live on the SKUs the rules cover.** We compare against the baseline:
  - stockout incidents, from distributor short-supply complaints and zero-stock weeks in SAP
  - write-off value, from the finance ledger
  - the share of SKUs within their target range at each run
  - time from SAP export to approved PO

- **Override rate.** Every edit or rejection is logged with the approver and a reason. A rising override rate means the rules are drifting away from how planners actually decide.

5 · Kill criterion: when to stop and redesign

- **Shadow mode:** the engine agrees with Raghav on **fewer than 80%** of the decisions the rules cover, even after the rules are tuned. That means the written rules aren't how he actually plans.
- **Live:** after one quarter, losses on covered SKUs are **not at least 10% below the baseline**, or the **override rate is above 30%**.
- **Operations:** IT cannot deliver the SAP export twice a week for 4 weeks in a row. Without fresh data the faster cycle is pointless.

Sources: Freshroots case brief (MESA Case 01, 22 Oct) and the SAP sample exports (sku_master, current_inventory, weekly_sales, calendar, distributor_master). Rupee figures are the company-wide losses reported in the brief. The reduction percentages are scenarios, not forecasts.